

When Size matters

Agent 001 goes shopping for the largest hard drive possible

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Just as hard drives have become ever cheaper, the demand for unlimited broadband connections has also risen. Users now tend to maintain their movie collections on hard drives. After all, one 500-GB HDD costs less than Rs. 3,000 now, and will store the contents of some 667 DVDs and an even larger number of CDs. Moreover, HD content is becoming the norm and each movie can be as much as 22 GB in size. That's about three dual-layer DVDs at a price of Rs. 100 each! I'm not saying the optical disk is dead. Blu-ray is one of its champions, and a worthy one at that. But for most people in India, Blu-ray is still a buzzword and purchasing Blu-ray movies is a costly affair. Additionally, there are those who wish to have the convenience of having their entire movie collection on a hard drive or two. And that's just movies; I haven't considered collectors of game ISO files. Before people cry *pirate*, let me assure you, I'm talking about legal content. When I purchase a DVD movie or a game, I always make sure to extract an ISO of the same and back it up on my local HDD — insurance against mishaps of any sort. I have lost a lot of movies that I legally bought over the years to damaged media and I can tell you its no laughing matter. It's also easier (infinitely so) to just mount an ISO or play a movie from my local hard drive than having to rummage in any of my six 100-disc CD pouches.

My quest for a large storage solution began courtesy of a friend, who asked me (as a favour) to find him a humongous external and internal solution for his new PC (he's a movie buff too). He is also into a lot of downloading of movies and these are carted around with him where ever he goes. Unfortunately, moving around with a 100 GB collection of FLAC files doesn't help either. I started doing a bit of Googling and called up a few of my favourite dealers at Lamington Road. My preliminary research taught me two things. First, internal hard drives are ridiculously cheap at the moment and anyone needing more storage should stop waiting and take the plunge. Second, external solutions have not really become cheaper over the past six months or so. However, larger solu-

tions have become available in the 2.5-inch HDD capacity due to increases in the areal density of platters. Earlier 250 GB notebook drives used to be the goliaths of the 2.5-inch HDD world. These days, 500-GB drives are available and besides double the storage over a 250-GB drive, they are also a bit faster. In fact, as hard drive platters get denser, the hard drive gets faster. Obviously, this is assuming that other things remain the same. This is because with the higher areal densities the read / write head can access more data with minimal mechanics.

If you're looking for an external solution via USB, a 2.5-inch form factor is the only way to go, in my opinion. Not only is this form factor much more compact, but also requires no external AC power connect, unlike 3.5-inch external solutions. For me, this is the main reason I avoid 3.5-inch hard drives. Since you're likely to be carrying your hard drive with you in your bag or backpack, the smaller form factor is also a great help. Speed junkies, do not be fooled by the fact that 2.5-inch solutions are slower than your 3.5-inch solutions. When looking at an external solution, it's the speed of the USB / FireWire interface, that is, by far, the main bottleneck. And there are 7,200-rpm, 2.5-inch drives around as well. Therefore, you don't have to be stuck with a slower performing 5,400-rpm solution. Obviously, people who copy 100 GB of data a day would still prefer a 3.5-inch external solution, but there are very few people with such colossal storage requirements. While storage size is a criterion for portable solutions, I personally don't mind a smaller portable HDD, because I make it a point to back up data and copy everything to my larger hard drive on my home PC. For such (non-lazy) users, depending on their data requirements, anything between 80 GB and 160 GB is enough. Data hogs with very huge amounts of data to back up should shop for a drive in the region of 320 GB. Also, larger drives are available but these aren't value for money, as their "cost-per-GB" is higher. However, prices are expected to fall over the next six months so watch out and monitor prices yourself too.

